

BOBBY JINDAL

THE INDIAN ROPE TRICK

Despite the anti-Republican wave across the US, an American of Indian origin has produced a miracle of sorts by becoming governor of Louisiana



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■ By Lavina Melwani

The anti-Republican wave sweeping across America has created something of a political miracle: in a reverse swing, it has swept Bobby Jindal, 36, an Asian-American and son of Punjabi immigrants into the Governor's mansion in a state known for its strong racial overtones. Jindal may provide the clichéd sound bites about "chasing the American dream", but it's a surreal victory in the context of the anti-Bush mood in the country right now. Jindal is undoubtedly a high flier, a man with ambition and charisma and to become not just the youngest Governor ever but the first non-white candidate to win such a top

post in highly conservative Louisiana is no mean achievement. The secret of his success is also the most controversial aspect of his campaign and indeed, his political makeup—his conservative Republican views, which have been traditionally associated with the Christian Right. Jindal may have sounded upbeat about what his victory meant ("Don't let anyone tell you any different; don't let anyone talk bad about Louisiana. Those days are now officially over. We are serving notice—Louisiana is very soon going to be on the rise."), but the long and tortured racial history of the southern state means his optimism could well be misplaced.

"It is still not clear whether this victory signifies that the race barriers

IMPRESSIVE: Jindal breaks new barriers but a tougher task lies ahead in Louisiana politics are eroding due to hurricane Katrina, or whether Asian-Americans are experiencing American society not primarily through the prism of race," says Dr Jamie Metz, executive vice-president of Asia Society. Indeed, one has to wonder how much of this was due to the vagaries of Katrina, where in a battered state grappling with corruption, lowest healthcare and funding than any state in the US, the people did turn colour-blind in the quest for good governance.

Even Indian-American reactions to Jindal's victory have been mixed. In many quarters, there's euphoria on hearing the words "Governor Bobby